

The Journey to the Land of Youth

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



The Journey to the Land of Youth

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

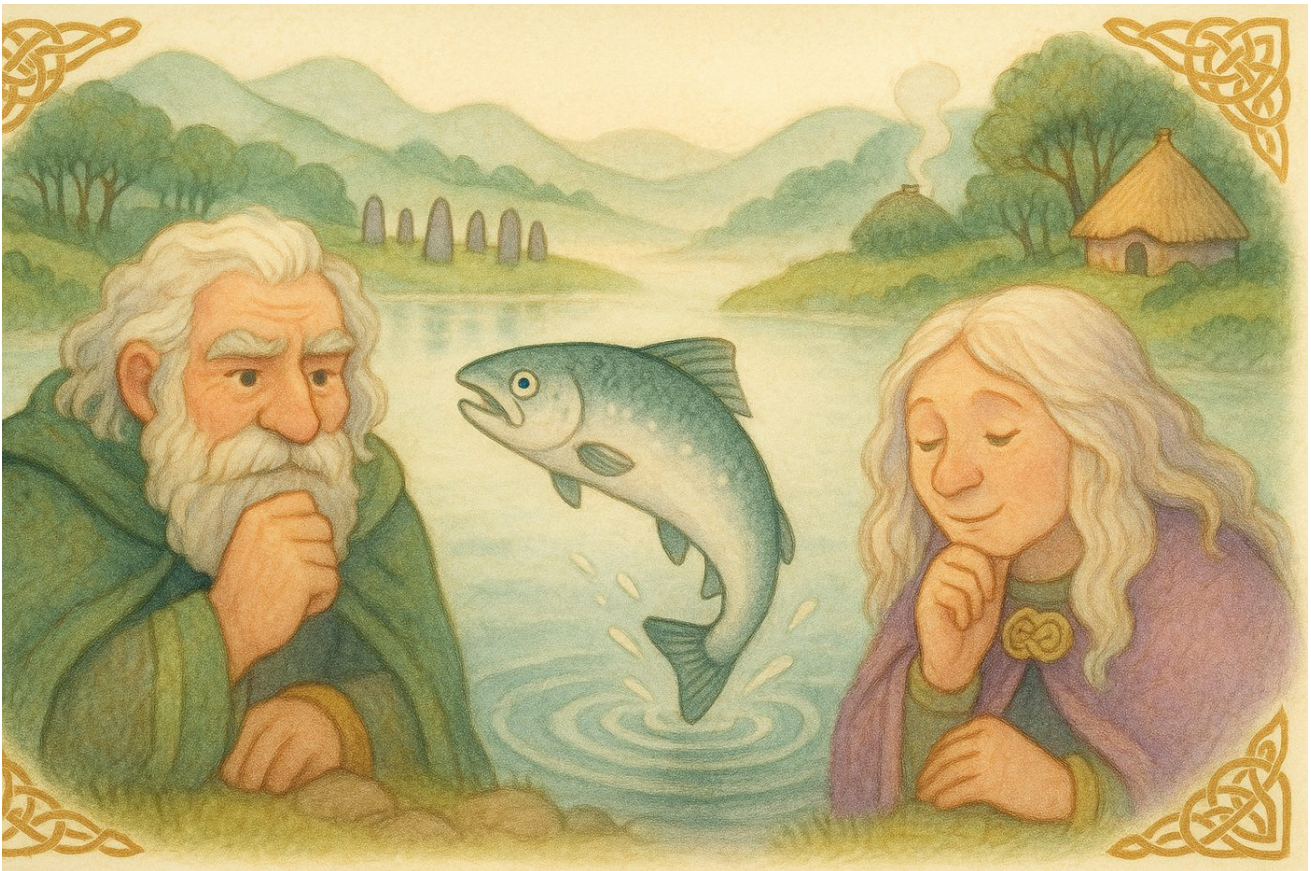
A small friend of the village has not come home. Yesterday, the story goes, they glimpsed a white deer at the edge of the trees and followed it, down to the Misty Loch and out across the still grey water, into the Land of Youth. That is the gentle Otherworld beyond the mist, once called Tir na nOg, where the apple trees are always in blossom and no one ever grows old. It is the loveliest place in any tale. That is exactly the danger of it: the longer a soul lingers there, the more they forget the faces and the way back home.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to the warm hearth of the Roundhouse. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth far more across the mist than any sword. Will you go after our friend and bring them home, gently, before the memory of us fades altogether?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a sprig of oak for luck, a honey oatcake wrapped in a cloth, and a ball of bright red wool. "Remember," she said, "across the mist we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind. And we keep our promises."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Cleverness, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Salmon's Riddle



The path led you down to the shore of the Misty Loch, where the water lay flat and grey and the far bank was lost in soft white mist. There seemed no way across at all, and no boat in sight.

Then the surface broke, and up rose a great old salmon, his scales bright as worn silver: the Salmon of Wisdom, who is said to know the answer to every riddle ever asked. "I know the way across the loch," he said, in a voice like slow water, "and I am glad to share it. But first you must answer a riddle of mine. I am fair, and I am kind, so think well and do not fear."

Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? A brave, thoughtful guess is welcome too, for the salmon is no trickster. What do you try?

When your answer came, the salmon dipped his great head and swished his tail, sending slow rings across the loch. "Well thought," he said, almost smiling, and he told you where on the shore to wait for the one who could carry you across.

Stop 2: The Selkie's Crossing



Where the salmon had pointed, among the whispering reeds, a small wooden boat lay ready, and beside it waited Sorchu the Selkie, a gentle seal-person wrapped in a soft grey sealskin cloak. She had dark, kind eyes, but she would not quite lift them to yours. She seemed terribly shy, and lonelier than the whole grey loch, as though no one had spoken a warm word to her in years.

This was never a thing to win by force. What kindness could you offer her? You might give her a gentle word, or tell her she is not alone, or share the honey oatcake that Maeve gave you. What do you do?

When you offered your kindness, something in Sorchu softened, and she smiled, slow and surprised, as if she had half forgotten how. "I will carry you across," she said quietly. "Climb in, and stay close." She took up the oars and rowed you out into the mist, and on the far shore, shimmering through the white, the Land of Youth came slowly into view.

Stop 3: The Land of Youth



You stepped from the boat into the Otherworld, and it took your breath away. Apple trees stood everywhere in soft pink blossom, the light fell warm and golden, and the air itself seemed to hum with a sleepy, happy peace. And there, in the middle of a meadow of flowers, was your small friend, laughing, as though no trouble had ever existed anywhere.

But when you called their name, they turned slowly, and their eyes were misty. "Oh," they said, "do I know you? It doesn't matter. Stay. Stay here with me. Nothing hurts here, and no one ever has to leave." It was the gentlest danger you had ever faced, and the hardest, because part of you wanted to stay too.

Then you remembered home: the warm hearth of the Roundhouse, the people who loved you, the way the Misty Loch caught the first light of dawn. You held that memory close, the way you hold the end of a thread.

This is not a fight, and there is nothing here to defeat. How will you help your friend remember home? You might tell them, gently, about the people waiting and the hearth still warm. You might tie the red wool fast so that none of you can lose the way back. What do you do, together?

Slowly, kindly, you gave your friend their home again: a name, a face, a warm hearth, a path through the mist. The fog lifted from their eyes, and they took your hand. "Home," they whispered. "I remember. Let's go home, all of us, together." You tied the red wool fast at the water's edge, and then you chose, every one of you, to turn back toward the boat.

Home Across the Mist



Sorcha was waiting, and she rowed you all back across the loch, the red wool slipping through your fingers to guide you, every pull of the oars carrying you nearer home. The mist thinned, then parted, and there was the green home shore, bright in the morning sun, your small friend safe and smiling between you.

You had come home together, and you had won a selkie friend besides, for Sorcha promised to visit the shallows whenever you called. High on the brightening green hills, Danu the Kind looked down and smiled, for the tale had ended the only way the best tales do: not by force, but with wits, with courage, and above all with kindness, and with a promise kept. Well done, heroes of the Emerald Isles.



My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

MY NAME

I AM A HERO OF

My energy



Colour one in when you spend it

My magics



My magic is _____

It can _____



My magic is _____

It can _____



My magic is _____

It can _____

What I carry

☐ _____

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Notes



Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.



Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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